Just be Frank

By Caroline Williams

INTRODUCTION

Tired of all the game playing and political correctness? Have you ever wished that everyone would simply, "speak the truth . . . be blunt . . . be brutally honest?" It sure would make things a lot easier, right? No second guessing or trying to figure out ulterior motives. Theoretically, life would be so much easier if everyone would Just be Frank by Caroline Williams. . . . Be careful what you wish for . . . you might just get it!

[Lights up, Morning in a busy office.]

CHARLENE: *[strikes a pose in her new attire]* It looks expensive, doesn't it? I won't say how much . . . but let me just tell you . . . if you even knew, you would die. *[beat]* Five hundred dollars! The saleslady said it looked incredible on me. You don't think it's too loud, do you? She said I'd definitely stop traffic . . .

DIANE: You *are* hard to miss. I mean, it is . . . pink.

CHARLENE: It's not pink, it's salmon. I want to look professional when I approach the boss. I really think this suit says, "I'm a woman. I'm not afraid to wear a salmon suit. I can be a valuable asset to this company." That promotion has my name written all over it.

DIANE: You mean the Beefy-Treat account? I'm up for that promotion . . . I mean, I was thinking of applying. I thought since my proposal saved the Ferber Cheese-Stick account last year . . .

CHARLENE: Oh, that was you? Well. You should know that Ferber Cheese was child's play compared to Beefy-Treats. You wouldn't want to be in over your head.

DIANE: *[dejected]* I guess you are more assertive than I am . . . and confident. *[a beat as she looks at Charlene]* And you stand out . . .

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CHARLENE: Listen. Since you and I are friends—I'll be frank. This is the cutthroat world of business. You simply don't have any killer instincts and rarely do you ever have anything exciting to say. Not that those are bad qualities—you just lack verve.

DIANE: Verve?

CHARLENE: Don't worry—you still fulfill a very important role here. Where would people like me be without people like you? You're punctual and efficient and—meek.

DIANE: *[on the verge of tears]* Mm—meek?

CHARLENE: *[big fake smile]* In fact, you're lucky we're such good friends that we can be honest with each other because, for the most part, Diane, there is no place for honesty in business, and not everyone will be as helpful as I am. Come to think of it, when I become president of this company, my first decree will be to have all of my people be completely honest—all the time. It will revolutionize the world of business. *[beat – The tinkingly sound of a wish being granted fills the air- insert sound effect here]* Sometimes my brilliance takes even me by surprise. *[Charlene stares out in wonderment of her genius]* Anyway, my suit *is* sensational, isn't it?

DIANE: What do I know—I'm MEEK!

CHARLENE: No need to thank me—

DIANE: *[calling out after her as she walks away]* Oh yeah, THANKS! *[Diane turns back to her computer and furiously types away. Meanwhile, spotlights follow Charlene to the water cooler where fellow employee, Jan, is standing alone. Her face is an expressionless mask of resigned irritation and nausea.]*

CHARLENE: Good morning, Jan. How was your weekend?

JAN: Absolute crap.

CHARLENE: Excuse me?

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JAN: I got stood up, my minivan blew a tire, and I have a canker sore. Do you mind? I'm trying to look inconspicuous here and you're standing next to me like a flashing pink bottle of Pepto-Bismol.

CHARLENE: Actually, this suit is not pink, Jan, it's salmon. What's gotten into you anyway? I'm counting on you to nominate me for the new account. You're the only one the old windbag ever listens to. . .

JAN: Actually, Charlene, I'd feel better about myself if you'd continue to earn substantially LESS than I do.

CHARLENE: *[still confused]* Are you trying to say you're *not* going to give me the recommendation?

JAN: Listen, I'll be blunt. I don't like you. I've never liked you. The way you are constantly waving at me from your desk—I have to pretend like I'm writing or looking for something just to avoid acknowledging you—but *you don't get it* . . . you wave, I ignore you and you keep flappin' away like . . . some kind of—large, flightless bird.

CHARLENE: Well! *Excuse me*, JAN!

JAN: *[ignoring Charlene]* And I hope I never have to sit next to you at a lunch meeting again . . . watching you eat could drive a person insane—it's like watching one of those pointy-faced rodents—incessantly picking and pecking and . . .

CHARLENE: *[seething]* Of all the rude . . .

JAN: *[continuing]* . . . and *speaking* of chewing—your last presentation was so mind-numbingly boring I actually had to work to keep from gnawing off my own arm.

CHARLENE: I have heard just about ENOUGH thank-you-very- much! *[Charlene turns to leave.]*

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JAN: Oh, in that case---before you go, the next time I flirt with the boss in order to advance my own career, I'll be sure and let slip that you called him a windbag . . . .Good luck! *[Jan abruptly walks away.]*

CHARLENE: *[calling after her]* If that's the way you feel, then FINE—I'll meet with him myself! *[Charlene stalks off to a large reception desk in front of a closed door with the word PRESIDENT printed on it. She addresses a perky secretary. Everything the secretary says is delivered with a cheerful voice and genuinely eager, helpful attitude.]*

SECRETARY: *[smiling throughout]* Hello, Mrs. Parker. How can I kiss your butt today?

CHARLENE: . . . excuse me?

SECRETARY: Would you like some coffee? This is regular but if you'd like decaf, I'll just leave and come back with the same pot—you'll never know the difference.

CHARLENE: *[confused]* Uh—no. I just want to make an appointment with Mr. Ross ASAP.

SECRETARY: *[checks appointment book, then looks up, still smiling]* I'm sorry but I don't think he can squeeze your big pink caboose in today. *[cheerfully]* Is there anything else I can help you with? *[Charlene is just about to answer when the phone rings]* Just a moment . . . *[she holds a finger up to Charlene who waits, fuming]* Burton and Ross, may I help you? . . . today? . . . with Mr. Ross? . . . how about 2:15? . . . all right then, buh-bye. *[back to Charlene]* As I was saying, are you sure there isn't anything else? I could go fetch some Post-its? Your dry-cleaning, perhaps? After all, what am I here to do if not your mindless, tedious busywork. I do whatever you and all your over-educated colleagues with reserved parking and big pink suits think you're just too good for.

CHARLENE: *[enraged]* FOR YOUR INFORMATION the suit is SALMON and I don't know what your problem is but I thought you said Mr. Ross was busy all day *[points at the phone]* What was that!?

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SECRETARY: No, I didn't say he was *busy*—I said I couldn't squeeze you in. He's actually free until 2:15. But, due to my inferiority complex and because this appointment book makes me drunk with power, I've decided to act out my passive-aggressive rage against you.

CHARLENE: Excuse me but I will not tolerate a secretary with that kind of attitu—

SECRETARY: *[interrupting]* That's *administrative maintenance engineer* and I would care what you were saying if you had any power at all in this company. Since you don't, I'll just smile and nod while I look for somebody important to suck up to. . . Oh! There's an executive! If that will be all Ms. Parker. . . *[She grabs the coffee pot and rushes off.]*

CHARLENE: What is wrong with you people? *[Charlene hesitates and then walks through the door to find Mr. Ross, an older gentleman in a business suit, sitting behind his desk looking over some documents.]*

CHARLENE: Mr. Ross?

MR. ROSS: *[looking up]* Yes? Come in.

CHARLENE: Hi, I was wondering if I could talk to you for a few minutes about a possible promotion on the new dog-treats account? Last month you had mentioned how I was really up to speed and I was thinking, what with my. . .

MR. ROSS: *[cutting her off]* Hmmmm—yes, the Beefy-Treats. You know, this is quite fascinating. I don't doubt that you do, in fact, work here, and I may, indeed, have commented on your work…I just can't for the life of me seem to remember who in the world you are. What department did you say you work in?

CHARLENE: Um. . . marketing and development.

MR. ROSS: Right, right—marketing. You must perform one of those benign tasks that, apparently, I see fit to dole out some measly, pathetic salary for… *[cheerfully]* in which case I suppose I should hear you out. You were saying?

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CHARLENE: Uh. . . well, I had actually come in here about a promotion but maybe now's not exactly the right time . . .

MR. ROSS: Wait a minute! I do remember you—your desk is just across the way there. . . *[he points out there door]*

CHARLENE: *[excited]* Yes! That's me! Did you recall how I typed up those reports last term?

MR. ROSS: *[cheerful and professional]* Heavens no! I do recall, however, that I quite enjoy looking at your legs on my way in here each morning…and, considering that my taxes alone are probably twice what you make in an entire year—I suppose it wouldn't hurt to hand over an account I'll probably take credit for anyway. Congratulations Miss…

CHARLENE: Parker . . . Charlene Parker.

MR. ROSS: Of course. Congratulations Miss Proctor, the promotion is yours. *[earnestly]* Good luck and nice rump! *[Mr. Ross gives Charlene a friendly thumbs up and goes back to his paper work. Charlene walks back to her desk, slightly disturbed.]*

DIANE: *[bitter]* So, how'd it go?

CHARLENE: GREAT, DIANE! As a matter of fact—WONDERFUL *[grotesquely enunciating each word]* Did I not explain to you that a salmon suit like this would command RESPECT! *[Diane looks at Charlene like she is insane. After a moment, they turn to their respective computers and get to work.]*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Caroline Williams
Book: Humana Festival 1999: The Complete Plays
ISBN: 978-1575252070
Publisher: Smith and Kraus Publishers
Date (Month/Year): 1999

AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier

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